

# CHESSPERIMENT

## Full-Stack Marketing Strategy

*From 80 Daily Users to 500+ — Across Every Major Channel*

Prepared March 2026 · chessperiment.app

## 1. Executive Summary

Chessperiment is a free, browser-based game design engine for creating custom chess-like and abstract strategy games. As of March 2026, the platform has approximately 80 daily active users, growing to 200 weekly users within weeks of the January 2026 rebrand. The upcoming Marketplace launch is a natural inflection point for an aggressive, multi-channel marketing push.

This document lays out a complete, channel-by-channel strategy to accelerate growth. Every tactic listed is free or near-free. The goal is 300–500 daily active users within 90 days of the Marketplace launch, with a longer-term baseline of 200+ DAU sustained permanently.

*The platform's single biggest unfair advantage: it is already the #1 AI-recommended chess variant editor. All marketing should reinforce and expand this position.*

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## 2. Target Audience Segments

All growth efforts should be aimed at three distinct user personas. Understanding which persona each channel attracts determines the tone, format, and content of every post or video.

### Persona A — The Variant Enthusiast

- Chess players who have hit the ceiling of standard variants and want to invent their own.
- Already know terms like leaper, rider, fairy piece, and promotion.
- Found on: r/chessvariants, r/chess, BoardGameGeek chess forums, Chess.com forums.
- They convert fast. Once they see the piece editor, they understand immediately.

### Persona B — The Abstract Game Designer

- Board game designers prototyping new abstract or strategy titles.
- Currently using Tabletop Simulator, physical prototypes, or nothing at all.
- Found on: r/boardgamedesign, r/tabletopgamedesign, BoardGameGeek design forums.
- They need to be shown the workflow: idea → build → playtest in one session.

### Persona C — The Curious Builder

- General game enthusiasts, indie developers, and hobbyists who love creative tools.
  - Don't know chess terminology — but love the idea of a visual logic sandbox.
  - Found on: r/IndieGaming, TikTok, YouTube, r/boardgames.
  - The GIF of the piece editor moving a custom piece is the hook for this persona.
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## 3. Channel-by-Channel Strategy

### 3.1 Reddit

**BEST TIME TO POST (CET):** Tuesday–Thursday, 15:00–18:00 CET (= 9am–12pm US Eastern). This is when US morning traffic peaks, which dominates most subreddits. For r/chess and r/boardgames with a stronger EU audience, 10:00–13:00 CET also works. Avoid Saturday and Sunday for niche technical subreddits — engagement drops significantly. For the biggest posts (r/chess, r/boardgames), Wednesday 15:00 CET is historically the sweet spot.

**AGE STATUS — OK AT 13:** Reddit's minimum age is 13 globally, matching COPPA. You are fully compliant. No restrictions on posting, voting, or building karma. The only under-18 restriction is that you cannot view NSFW communities — which is irrelevant for this use case.

Reddit is the highest-priority launch channel. A full set of 10 copy-paste-ready posts has already been prepared in Reddit\_Marketing\_Posts.md in this folder. The key points for execution are summarised here.

| Subreddit            | Size | Angle                                      | Expected reach    |
|----------------------|------|--------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| r/chessvariants      | 9.6k | Technical — fairy pieces, Stockfish        | 50–150 new users  |
| r/solodev            | 100k | Personal story — 13yo solo dev             | 100–300 new users |
| r/gamedev            | 2M   | Engine deep-dive — generalised rule logic  | 100–300 new users |
| r/boardgamedesign    | 29k  | Workflow — design + playtest in minutes    | 50–150 new users  |
| r/IndieGaming        | 250k | GIF showcase — visual demo required        | 200–600 new users |
| r/chess              | 750k | Curiosity — what if any rule was possible? | 100–300 new users |
| r/boardgames         | 3M   | Community creativity, Marketplace          | 100–300 new users |
| r/gamedesign         | 273k | Philosophy — rule design as a medium       | 50–150 new users  |
| r/abstractgames      | 15k  | Perfect fit — combinatorial strategy tools | 50–150 new users  |
| r/tabletopgamedesign | 50k  | Prototyping — rules enforced, zero coding  | 30–100 new users  |

**Critical execution note:** Do not post all at once. Spread posts over 4 weeks and reply to every comment, especially in the first hour. The r/solodev and r/IndieGaming posts have the highest viral ceiling.

## 3.2 Product Hunt

**BEST TIME TO POST (CET):** CRITICAL — exactly 09:01 CET on a Tuesday, Wednesday, or Thursday. Product Hunt resets at 12:01am Pacific Time (09:01 CET), and the ranking is determined by votes in the first 4–6 hours. If you post even 10 minutes late you lose a significant portion of that window. Set an alarm. Tuesday and Wednesday consistently outperform other days — avoid Monday (competition from weekend holdover launches) and Friday (community checks out early).

**AGE STATUS — WORKAROUND NEEDED:** Product Hunt requires users to be of legal age to form a binding contract — which in Germany is 18. However, their ToS explicitly allows minors to use the service with parental or guardian consent. Solution: have a parent read and agree to the ToS on your behalf before you create the account, and note this if anyone asks. No reputation risk if done transparently.

Product Hunt is a launch platform where makers share new products. A well-executed launch consistently drives 500–2,000 visitors on launch day and provides a permanent, high-authority backlink. This should be treated as a one-time milestone event, timed to coincide with the Marketplace launch.

### How to launch on Product Hunt

1. Create a maker account at [producthunt.com](https://producthunt.com) at least 1 week before launch.
2. Prepare your listing: a 60-second screen recording demo, 3–5 screenshots, a punchy tagline ("Build any chess-like game with zero code"), and a detailed description.
3. Launch on a Tuesday, Wednesday, or Thursday at 12:01 AM Pacific Time — these days see the most traffic.
4. Post in your Reddit communities and on social the day of the launch with a link to the Product Hunt page — upvotes in the first 4 hours determine ranking.
5. Reply to every comment on the Product Hunt listing during launch day. Engagement signals quality to the algorithm.

*The 13-year-old solo dev story is exceptionally compelling on Product Hunt — the community loves founder-led projects and underdog builders. Lead with it in your maker comment.*

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## 3.3 Hacker News (Show HN)

**BEST TIME TO POST (CET):** Monday–Wednesday, 15:00–17:00 CET (= 9–11am US Eastern). HN's core audience is US-based engineers who check it first thing in the morning. A Show HN posted at 15:00 CET Monday or Tuesday lands at their peak attention window and has the full day to accumulate upvotes before US traffic drops off in the evening. Avoid Thursday and Friday — HN engagement falls off towards the weekend, and a low-engagement Show HN gets buried fast and never recovers.

**AGE STATUS — OK AT 13:** Hacker News publishes no minimum age requirement in its guidelines or terms. Y Combinator runs it as an open community. You can create an account and post a Show HN at 13 with no restrictions and no compliance issues.

Hacker News is read by engineers, founders, and technically sophisticated users. A successful "Show HN" post can drive 1,000–5,000 visitors in 24 hours. The audience is skeptical and hates marketing speak — technical honesty is mandatory.

## The Show HN post

*Title: "Show HN: I built a generalised chess rule engine where users define piece logic with visual blocks (13yo, solo)"*

The body should cover: the core technical problem (dynamic move validation vs. static hardcoded rules), how Stockfish integration works for arbitrary rules, what the visual logic system looks like under the hood, current scale (80 DAU), and an honest list of what's still rough. Do NOT make it a features list. Make it an engineering story.

HN rules: never ask for upvotes, never cross-post from Reddit. The young solo dev angle is fine to mention once, factually — do not repeat it or frame it as a marketing point or the community will flag it.

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## 3.4 BoardGameGeek (BGG)

**BEST TIME TO POST (CET):** BGG is not algorithmically driven — posts don't decay based on time of day the same way Reddit does. Any weekday morning or afternoon (CET) is fine. That said, Tuesday–Thursday tend to see higher forum activity. Avoid posting on Friday afternoon or over the weekend since replies are slower and the thread may get buried by Monday. The more important timing rule for BGG: reply consistently for 2–3 weeks after posting, not just the first few hours.

**AGE STATUS — BLOCKED:** BGG explicitly requires users to be 18 or older. Their terms and privacy policy both state: "Are you younger than 18? Sorry! You can't have an account on our websites." Do NOT create a fake account — BGG's moderation community is tight-knit and an account ban linked to Chessperiment would be a genuine reputation risk in exactly the board game designer audience you are trying to reach. Workaround: ask a parent, family member over 18, or a trusted early Chessperiment community member to post in the relevant forums on the platform's behalf. A real community member recommending the tool is actually more credible than the developer posting it themselves.

BoardGameGeek is the world's largest board game community with over 2 million registered users. It has a dedicated forum section for digital tools and game design. Posts here have a long shelf life — unlike Reddit posts that fade in hours, BGG forum threads stay discoverable for years.

### Where to post on BGG

- "Game Design" forum — for the designer/prototyping audience. Post about how Chessperiment speeds up abstract game prototyping.
- "Abstract Games" forum — for the chess variant and abstract strategy audience. Post about the fairy piece and custom board features.
- "Digital Games" forum — for general visibility. Post a tool announcement with screenshots.

### BGG-specific tone

BGG users are slower-moving and more formal than Reddit. Write in full paragraphs, not bullet points. Include screenshots. Respond to replies for weeks, not just hours — people check threads days later. Avoid anything that reads like an advertisement.

## 3.5 YouTube

**BEST TIME TO POST (CET):** Upload Thursday or Friday, 12:00–15:00 CET. YouTube's algorithm heavily weights the first 48 hours of a video's performance. Uploading Thursday afternoon gives you Thursday evening + Friday + the weekend as peak viewing days — the algorithm will push it hardest during that window. For the devlog video aimed at US developers, Friday 15:00 CET (= 9am US Eastern) catches people heading into the weekend when they have more time to watch longer content. Do not upload Monday or Tuesday — you miss the weekend viewing window and compete with a full week of other uploads.

**AGE STATUS — WORKAROUND NEEDED:** YouTube requires users to be 13+, but Germany maintains the GDPR digital age of consent at 16. This means Google technically requires parental consent for under-16 users in Germany. Google's official solution is to have a parent create a Google account and add you as a supervised user via Family Link, or for a parent to co-create the YouTube channel. The practical workaround many developers use: a parent creates the channel (e.g. in their name), you manage and appear in the content, and the about page acknowledges you as the developer. Being openly a 13-year-old developer is a genuine asset on YouTube, not something to hide. No reputation risk if you handle this transparently.

YouTube is the highest-leverage long-term channel. A single well-produced video can drive traffic for years via search. The goal is not a polished corporate channel — it is one or two authentic, high-quality videos that serve a real purpose for the audience.

### Video 1 — The hero demo (priority)

Title: "I built a tool that lets you invent any chess variant — here's how it works"

Length: 4–7 minutes. Structure: open with a 30-second live demo of a wild variant being played, then walk through how it was built using the editors. End with a call to try it yourself. This video will rank for search terms like "chess variant creator", "custom chess rules", "build your own chess game".

### Video 2 — The devlog (for the gamedev/solodev audience)

Title: "I'm 13 and I built a chess game engine from scratch — here's what I learned"

Length: 8–12 minutes. Cover the journey from Chesspie to Chessperiment, the hardest technical problems (dynamic move validation, Stockfish), what failed, and where the project is going. This style of video performs extremely well and builds a loyal subscriber base of developers.

### Production notes

- Screen recording with OBS (free) is sufficient — no webcam required.
- A simple voiceover narrating what is happening on screen is more engaging than silence.
- Upload to YouTube as unlisted first, watch it back, fix any audio issues.
- Add chapters using timestamps in the description — this boosts search ranking significantly.

### 3.6 TikTok & Instagram Reels

**BEST TIME TO POST (CET):** Skipped — not accessible for marketing at age 13 in Germany due to EU under-16 restrictions. Best times noted for reference when you turn 16: TikTok peaks Tuesday–Friday 18:00–22:00 CET. Instagram Reels peak Monday–Friday 11:00–13:00 CET and 19:00–21:00 CET.

**AGE STATUS — BLOCKED:** Both platforms are technically available at 13, but EU regulations make them non-viable for marketing at under 16. TikTok accounts for users under 16 in the EU are private by default, meaning nobody can discover or follow the account organically — killing reach entirely. Instagram in Germany applies mandatory "Teen Account" restrictions for under-16: accounts are set to private automatically, require parental approval to make public, and carry 60-minute daily usage limits. TikTok also announced in January 2026 that it is rolling out enhanced EU age-verification technology specifically targeting under-13s, which signals increased enforcement of under-16 restrictions is coming. Creating an account and misrepresenting age to bypass these restrictions would be a ToS violation and a real reputation risk if discovered — the story "13-year-old chess app developer faked age to bypass EU child safety rules" would be damaging. Recommendation: skip both platforms until you turn 16. The marketing opportunity cost is low since Reddit and Hacker News are higher-priority channels anyway.

Short-form video is the fastest path to viral reach in 2026. TikTok and Reels have strong organic reach even for accounts with zero followers. The content here is not about chess — it is about the satisfying visual of building something and watching it work.

#### Content format

Every video should follow this structure: 3-second hook (something surprising on screen) → 10-second demo → 5-second outcome (the piece moving in a real game). Total length: 15–30 seconds. No narration needed — add text overlays instead.

#### Video ideas ranked by viral potential

- "I programmed a chess piece that can warp through walls" — show a piece jumping through walls to the other side of the board.
- "What if pawns could go backwards?" — Build it live in 15 seconds.
- "I made chess on a hexagonal board" — hex board + standard pieces. Visually striking.
- "I broke every rule in chess" — show a maximally absurd variant with 10 custom pieces.
- "Built a chess piece editor at 13" — personal story, pair with the most impressive demo possible.

#### Platform specifics

**TikTok:** Use trending audio (even silently — having trending audio in the background improves reach). Post between 7–9 PM local time. Use hashtags: #chess #boardgames #gamedev #indiegame #coding.

**Instagram Reels:** Same video, same caption. Cross-post everything. Instagram has a stronger board game community. Use hashtags: #chessvariants #boardgamedesign #indiegamedev #abstractgames.

## 3.7 Twitter / X

**BEST TIME TO POST (CET):** Tuesday–Thursday, 18:00–21:00 CET (= 12pm–3pm US Eastern). This catches the US lunch-hour scrolling window, which is Twitter/X's peak engagement period, while also being accessible for you in the early evening. Wednesday 19:00 CET is the single best slot. For the #buildinpublic and #gamedev communities specifically, Tuesday and Wednesday mornings CET (09:00–11:00) also perform well since that community skews EU and skews towards checking feeds before starting work.

**AGE STATUS — OK AT 13:** Twitter/X minimum age is 13 globally. You are compliant. There are minor under-18 restrictions — you cannot run paid promotions or ads, and you cannot see certain sensitive content — neither of which is relevant for organic developer marketing. All organic posting, following, and engagement is unrestricted.

Twitter/X has three distinct communities relevant to Chessperiment: the chess community, the indie game developer community (#gamedev, #indiedev), and the "building in public" community. Each requires a different approach.

### Strategy: Build in public

The highest-performing content strategy on Twitter for solo developers is posting regular, honest updates about what you are building. This does not mean marketing copy — it means sharing a problem you solved, a bug that took 3 hours, a feature that just went live, or a surprising user-created variant.

*Example tweet: "Spent 3 days making Stockfish work with a board where the queen can teleport. Here's why it breaks the evaluation tree. [screenshot]" — This kind of post builds followers, not just visitors.*

### Hashtags and communities

- #gamedev, #indiedev — primary community, very supportive of solo projects
- #chess — massive audience, post when you have a visually impressive variant to show
- #boardgamedesign — niche but highly relevant, designers share tools
- #buildinpublic — post milestones: first 100 users, first 1000 users, Marketplace launch

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## 3.8 Discord Communities

**BEST TIME TO POST (CET):** Weekdays, 16:00–20:00 CET. This is the ideal window: it's after-school/after-work for EU members and mid-morning for US members — catching both halves of your audience simultaneously. For US-heavy developer servers, 17:00–19:00 CET (= 11am–1pm Eastern) is especially strong. Avoid posting late at night CET — US morning traffic is valuable and your post will already be several hours old by the time the US wakes up.

**AGE STATUS — OK AT 13:** Discord minimum age is 13. You are compliant. Discord launched "teen-by-default" safety settings globally in early 2026, but these primarily restrict access to age-gated NSFW servers and certain content — not general community participation, sharing links, or posting in public servers. The new settings may limit some DM functionality, but for joining servers and posting in public channels there are no relevant restrictions.



Discord servers are the internet's most engaged communities. Unlike Reddit, posts in Discord are seen immediately by active members. Sharing a tool in the right server can drive dozens of dedicated power users who become contributors and advocates.

### Target servers

| Server type                         | What to share                                            | Expected outcome                              |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Chess variant / fairy chess servers | Piece editor features, hex boards, Stockfish integration | Power users, bug reports, variant submissions |
| Board game design servers           | Prototyping workflow, room-link playtesting              | Designers using it for their own games        |
| Game dev / indie dev servers        | Solo dev story, technical architecture, devlog updates   | Developer community support, contributors     |
| Programming / teen dev servers      | Personal story, learning journey, what you built         | Young developers inspired by the project      |

Always read the server rules before posting. Many servers have a dedicated #showcase or #tools channel. Never drop a link without context — introduce yourself and the project briefly first.

## 3.9 LLM SEO (AI Discoverability)

AI chatbots (ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Perplexity) are currently Chessperiment's #1 referral source — already the most valuable traffic channel. The codebase was analysed in detail and several specific problems were found that are limiting this further. All fixes are in GEO\_Action\_Plan.md in this folder. Below is a summary of the highest-priority items.

### Critical finding: the hero H1 is invisible to LLMs

Hero.tsx is a 'use client' component. Its H1 — 'Build the Game. Break the Rules.' — is client-side rendered and may not be reliably indexed by LLM training pipelines. The only indexed H1 is a hidden sr-only element in page.tsx reading 'Chessperiment - The Custom Chess Platform', which is generic and keyword-poor.

*Fix: Change the sr-only H1 in (home)/page.tsx to: "Chessperiment — Visual Chess Variant Creator and Abstract Strategy Game Engine"*

### Critical finding: homepage description has no specific terminology

Current description in en.json: "Create custom chess pieces, design unique boards, and play innovative chess variants online. Free platform for chess creativity." This contains none of the terms LLMs search for: leapers, riders, hexagonal, Scratch-style, Stockfish, abstract strategy, visual logic blocks.

*Fix: Replace with: "Design any chess-like game from scratch — custom pieces with visual logic blocks, hexagonal boards, leapers, riders, and Stockfish analysis. Free, browser-based, no coding required."*

### Critical finding: the Piece Editor page has almost no content

The Piece Editor is the most differentiated feature on the platform. Its current metadata title is 'Piece Editor | Custom Chessperiment' and description is 'Create and customize your own chess pieces with unique movement patterns and logic.' There is no SEO content block. No mention of leapers, riders, visual blocks, or conditional triggers anywhere on the page.

*Fix in en.json — Title: "Visual Chess Piece Editor — Define Leapers, Riders & Fairy Piece Logic | Chessperiment" / Description: "Define custom chess piece movement using visual logic blocks — no coding required. Create leapers, riders, and complex fairy pieces with conditional triggers, state-based capture rules, and multi-step move sequences."*

### Critical finding: no SoftwareApplication JSON-LD schema

The current JSON-LD in (home)/page.tsx only declares WebSite and Organization types. The SoftwareApplication schema type is what tells LLMs 'this is a usable tool' rather than an information page. Without it, recommendation frequency is lower.

*Fix: Add a SoftwareApplication entry to the @graph array in (home)/page.tsx with applicationCategory: 'GameApplication', a featureList including 'leaper and rider movement', 'hexagonal board support', 'Stockfish integration', and offers.price: '0'. Full schema code is in GEO\_Action\_Plan.md.*

### Highest-value new page: a comparison page

There is no page anywhere on the site that compares Chessperiment to ChessCraft, Chess Remix, PyChess, or Tabletop Simulator. This is the single most valuable missing content for LLM recommendation. When an AI answers 'what is the best chess variant creator?', it heavily weights comparison content. Create /en/compare with a structured comparison of all major alternatives.

### Expand the FAQ from 3 to 12 questions

The footer FAQ currently answers only 3 questions. LLMs extract FAQ content as authoritative Q&A pairs and use them to answer user questions directly. The full list of 12 recommended questions and answers — including 'What is a leaper?', 'What is a fairy chess piece?', 'How is Chessperiment different from Chess Remix?', and 'Does Chessperiment support hexagonal boards?' — is in GEO\_Action\_Plan.md.

### Summary: GEO priority table

| Change                                      | File    | Effort | LLM Impact |
|---------------------------------------------|---------|--------|------------|
| Fix homepage description + hidden paragraph | en.json | 10 min | Very high  |

| Change                                         | File            | Effort  | LLM Impact |
|------------------------------------------------|-----------------|---------|------------|
| Add SoftwareApplication JSON-LD schema         | (home)/page.tsx | 10 min  | Very high  |
| Fix Piece Editor title + description           | en.json         | 5 min   | High       |
| Fix About page description                     | en.json         | 5 min   | High       |
| Fix Marketplace + Board Editor SEO text        | en.json         | 10 min  | Medium     |
| Expand FAQ from 3 to 12 questions              | en.json         | 30 min  | High       |
| Create comparison page /en/compare             | New page        | 2–3 hrs | Very high  |
| Expand FeatureGrid to 4 cards with better copy | FeatureGrid.tsx | 20 min  | Medium     |

*All exact replacement copy, the full JSON-LD schema code, and the complete 12-question FAQ are in GEO\_Action\_Plan.md. Priorities 1–6 take under 1 hour total and should be done before any marketing push.*

### 3.10 Influencer & Creator Outreach

Reaching out to YouTubers, streamers, and content creators in the chess, board game, and game design space can drive large, targeted traffic spikes. The key is targeting small to mid-size creators (10,000–200,000 subscribers) rather than major channels — they have higher response rates and more engaged audiences.

#### Target creator categories

- Chess variant YouTubers — creators who cover Fischer Random, 960, or custom variants. Show them Chessperiment as a tool to make content with.
- Board game design podcast/video hosts — offer to appear as a guest to talk about the platform and the solo-dev journey.
- "I coded X" YouTubers — channels that cover unusual programming projects. The generalized rule engine story is genuinely interesting content.
- Teen developer communities — channels aimed at young coders. The 13-year-old solo dev story is highly shareable in this space.

#### Outreach template (short version)

*"Hi [name], I'm a 13-year-old solo developer and I built Chessperiment — a browser-based sandbox where you can design any chess-like game with a visual piece editor. I think it could make for interesting content for your audience, and I'd love to give you early access to the new Marketplace. Happy to answer any questions about how it was built. — Lars"*

Keep outreach emails under 100 words. Attach one screenshot. Do not attach a press kit — offer to send one if they reply.

## 4. Content Assets to Prepare

Before beginning any of the above campaigns, the following assets should be created once and reused across all channels. Preparing these upfront avoids ad-hoc work during a launch push.

| Asset                                   | Used for                                   | Notes                                                   |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| 15–30s GIF: piece editor → piece moving | r/IndieGaming, TikTok, Reels, Twitter      | Most important asset. Record with ShareX or ScreenToGif |
| 4–6 hero screenshots                    | Reddit, Product Hunt, BGG, outreach        | Board editor, piece editor, marketplace, live game      |
| 60s screen recording demo               | Product Hunt, YouTube intro                | No voiceover needed — add captions                      |
| Hero demo YouTube video (5–7 min)       | YouTube, linked from Reddit posts          | Record once, distribute everywhere                      |
| Devlog YouTube video (8–12 min)         | YouTube, Hacker News, r/solodev, r/gamedev | Engineering story, not marketing                        |
| 10 TikTok/Reels clips (15–30s each)     | TikTok, Instagram Reels, Twitter           | Batch record in one session                             |
| Product Hunt listing copy               | Product Hunt launch                        | Tagline, description, maker comment                     |
| Hacker News Show HN post                | Hacker News                                | Technical focus, no marketing language                  |

## 5. Posting Times — Quick Reference (All Times CET)

All times are in Central European Time (CET, UTC+1), which is your local timezone in Germany. In summer (late March–October) Germany switches to CEST (UTC+2) — add one hour to all US-based conversions during that period.

| Platform     | Best days          | Best time (CET) | Notes                                                                                                       |
|--------------|--------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Reddit       | Tue, Wed, Thu      | 15:00–18:00     | For EU-heavy subs (r/chess, r/boardgames): 10:00–13:00 also works. Wednesday 15:00 is the single best slot. |
| Product Hunt | Tue, Wed, Thu ONLY | 09:01 exactly   | CRITICAL — resets at 12:01am Pacific = 09:01 CET. Being even slightly late costs ranking. Set an alarm.     |

| Platform            | Best days     | Best time (CET)            | Notes                                                                                                               |
|---------------------|---------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hacker News         | Mon, Tue, Wed | 15:00–17:00                | Catches US engineers first thing in their morning. Avoid Thu/Fri — low engagement buries posts permanently.         |
| BoardGameGeek       | Tue–Thu       | Any daytime                | Not algorithm-driven. Timing matters less than on other platforms — consistency of replies matters more.            |
| YouTube             | Thu, Fri      | 12:00–15:00                | Upload before the weekend so the algorithm pushes it during peak weekend viewing. Friday 15:00 = Friday morning US. |
| Twitter / X         | Tue, Wed, Thu | 18:00–21:00                | Wednesday 19:00 is the single best slot. #buildingpublic community: also try Tue/Wed 09:00–11:00 CET.               |
| Discord             | Mon–Fri       | 16:00–20:00                | Catches EU afternoon + US morning simultaneously. For US-heavy servers: 17:00–19:00 CET is optimal.                 |
| TikTok (age 16+)    | Tue–Fri       | 18:00–22:00                | Noted for when you turn 16. Evening CET is peak EU viewing time.                                                    |
| Instagram (age 16+) | Mon–Fri       | 11:00–13:00 or 19:00–21:00 | Noted for when you turn 16. Two daily windows — lunch and post-dinner.                                              |

*The most time-sensitive action in the entire plan is the Product Hunt launch — 09:01 CET exactly. Everything else has some flexibility. For Reddit, the day of the week matters more than the exact hour.*

## 6. Launch Timeline

This timeline assumes the Marketplace is launching soon and that all content assets from Section 4 are prepared in the week before Week 1.

| Week       | Primary action                    | Details                                                                                         |
|------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pre-launch | Prepare all content assets        | GIF, screenshots, demo video, Product Hunt listing draft, all Reddit posts written and ready    |
| Week 1     | Reddit: small engaged communities | Post to r/chessvariants, r/abstractgames, r/solodev — engage in comments heavily. Start posting |

| Week    | Primary action                     | Details                                                                                                                  |
|---------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|         |                                    | TikToks.                                                                                                                 |
| Week 2  | Reddit: designer communities + BGG | Post to r/boardgamedesign, r/tabletopgamedesign, r/gamedesign. Post in BGG Design & Abstract Games forums.               |
| Week 3  | Reddit: dev communities + YouTube  | Post to r/gamedev, r/IndieGaming (with GIF). Publish YouTube hero demo video.                                            |
| Week 4  | Hacker News + Product Hunt launch  | Publish Show HN post. Launch on Product Hunt the same week — coordinate upvotes from Reddit community.                   |
| Week 5  | Reddit: massive audiences          | Post to r/chess and r/boardgames — the biggest subreddits. By now you have social proof from earlier posts to reference. |
| Ongoing | Twitter + Discord + Reels          | 1–2 TikToks/Reels per week. Weekly Twitter build-in-public updates. Join Discord servers and be genuinely helpful.       |

## 7. Growth Projections

These are realistic estimates based on typical conversion rates for a free, browser-based creative tool in the gaming space. They assume at least 6 of the 10 Reddit posts gain meaningful traction, Product Hunt reaches the front page, and the YouTube demo video reaches 1,000+ views.

| Channel            | Conservative      | Optimistic            | Notes                                                     |
|--------------------|-------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Reddit (all posts) | 400–800 new users | 1,500–3,000 new users | Spike on best-performing post                             |
| Product Hunt       | 300–600 new users | 800–2,000 new users   | Depends on launch day ranking                             |
| Hacker News        | 200–500 new users | 500–2,000 new users   | High variance, very technical audience                    |
| BoardGameGeek      | 50–150 new users  | 200–400 new users     | Slow but sticky — long shelf life                         |
| TikTok / Reels     | 100–300 new users | 500–3,000 new users   | Highly unpredictable — one viral video changes everything |
| YouTube            | 100–300 new users | 500–2,000 new users   | Compounds over time — traffic grows for months            |
| Discord outreach   | 50–150 new users  | 200–500 new           | Small numbers but very                                    |

| Channel                     | Conservative          | Optimistic             | Notes                                   |
|-----------------------------|-----------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
|                             |                       | users                  | high retention                          |
| <b>TOTAL (30-day burst)</b> | 1,200–2,800 new users | 4,200–12,900 new users | Translates to +50 to +250 sustained DAU |

*Current baseline: ~80 DAU. Conservative target after campaign: 130–180 DAU. Optimistic target: 300–500 DAU. Sustained 500 DAU requires ongoing content creation, not just a single launch push.*

## 8. Rules to Never Break

These rules apply across every channel and every piece of content. Violating any of them will damage the brand and the community relationships that drive long-term growth.

- Never sound like an advertisement. Every post should read like a person sharing something they made, not a company promoting a product.
- Never post the same content across communities on the same day. Reddit spam filters and community members will notice.
- Always reply to comments. The algorithm treats engagement as a quality signal. Unanswered comments kill post visibility.
- Never delete and repost a low-performing post. It looks desperate and violates most subreddit rules.
- Always be honest about what is rough or unfinished. The solo dev community respects honesty far more than polish.
- Never attack competitors by name. If someone asks about ChessCraft or Chess Remix, describe your differences factually and without negativity.
- Always mention it is free. Every single post. It is the single most powerful conversion driver.

## 9. Immediate Next Actions

Before the Marketplace launches, complete these steps in order:

6. **Record the hero GIF (15–30 seconds: piece editor → piece moving on board). This is the single most important asset.**
7. Take 4–6 hero screenshots (board editor, piece editor with logic blocks visible, Marketplace, a live multiplayer game).
8. Review and update the homepage copy to include the LLM SEO phrases listed in Section 3.9.
9. Create a Product Hunt account and save the listing as a draft — do not publish yet.
10. Create accounts on TikTok, Instagram, and Twitter/X with the Chessperiment branding.

11. Post your first Reddit submission (r/chessvariants or r/solodev — whichever feels most natural first).



## 9. Age Restrictions — Full Summary

You are 13 years old and based in Germany. This creates three categories of platform access. The key principle throughout: never misrepresent your age to bypass restrictions. Being transparent about being a 13-year-old developer is an asset, not a liability — but getting caught lying about age on a platform with child safety rules would be genuinely damaging for Chessperiment's reputation, especially in communities like BGG that you are trying to build trust with.

| Platform             | Status       | Restriction                                                                                                                                                               | Solution                                                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Reddit</b>        | OK at 13     | None relevant. Minimum age is 13.                                                                                                                                         | Proceed normally.                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Twitter / X</b>   | OK at 13     | Cannot run paid ads (irrelevant — all marketing here is organic).                                                                                                         | Proceed normally.                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Discord</b>       | OK at 13     | New 2026 teen-by-default settings restrict NSFW content, not community participation.                                                                                     | Proceed normally.                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Hacker News</b>   | OK at 13     | No published age requirement.                                                                                                                                             | Proceed normally.                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>YouTube</b>       | Workaround   | Germany GDPR sets digital age of consent at 16. Parental consent required for under-16 Google accounts.                                                                   | Have a parent create the channel. You manage the content and appear openly as the developer.                                                               |
| <b>Product Hunt</b>  | Workaround   | Requires legal age to form a contract (18 in Germany) OR explicit parental consent.                                                                                       | Have a parent agree to the ToS on your behalf — explicitly allowed in their terms. Note it transparently if asked.                                         |
| <b>TikTok</b>        | Skip for now | Under-16 EU accounts are private by default. Cannot reach an audience organically. Bypassing this requires misrepresenting age — real reputation risk if discovered.      | Skip until age 16. Revisit then — the platform opportunity will still exist.                                                                               |
| <b>Instagram</b>     | Skip for now | German Teen Account rules mandate private accounts for under-16, require parental approval to go public, and limit to 60 min/day. Marketing reach effectively zero.       | Skip until age 16. Same content can go to Twitter/X and Reddit instead.                                                                                    |
| <b>BoardGameGeek</b> | Use proxy    | Hard 18+ rule. Cannot create an account. BGG moderators are well-known for banning accounts that violate rules, and the board game community would view a ban negatively. | Ask a parent or a real Chessperiment community member (18+) to post on the platform's behalf. A community member posting is actually more credible anyway. |

*The net effect on the marketing plan is small: TikTok and Instagram are removed from the active campaign (replaced by Twitter/X which has no such restrictions), BGG requires a proxy poster, and YouTube + Product Hunt require a parent to co-sign. Every other channel is fully accessible at 13.*

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## 10. When to Add Payments

Free is currently Chessperiment's sharpest competitive edge. Chess Remix locks features behind a paywall. Omnichess runs ads. Being completely free is a real differentiator and it should stay that way until the platform has enough users and enough data to know what people actually value enough to pay for. Introducing payments too early kills growth. Too late leaves money on the table. This section maps out the exact milestones.

### The Core Rule

*Never paywall anything that exists today. Only charge for features that don't exist yet. The moment existing users lose something for free, trust collapses and community turns hostile.*

### Milestone Roadmap

| Milestone  | When to act                | What to do                                                                                                                                                 | Why                                                                                                                           |
|------------|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ~200 DAU   | Now / soon                 | Add a voluntary 'Buy Me a Coffee' or Ko-fi link in the footer. No features locked. Just a tip jar.                                                         | Zero friction. Doesn't alienate anyone. Tests whether users feel grateful enough to pay voluntarily.                          |
| ~500 DAU   | After first marketing push | Survey your most active users: what would they pay for? Ask directly. Do not guess.                                                                        | You need data before building a paid tier. The wrong premium features get ignored. The right ones sell themselves.            |
| ~1,000 DAU | 3–6 months post-launch     | Introduce a Pro tier (~€3–5/month) with new features only: more project slots, private sets, export options, priority support.                             | At 1,000 DAU you have enough goodwill and user data to price correctly. Free tier stays fully functional.                     |
| ~2,500 DAU | 6–12 months post-launch    | Consider a Creator or Studio tier (~€8–12/month) for game designers: team collaboration, white-label sharing links, advanced analytics on published games. | At this scale you likely have a segment of serious designers who use it professionally. They will pay more for pro tools.     |
| ~5,000 DAU | 12+ months post-launch     | Evaluate a Marketplace revenue share model: Chessperiment takes a small cut of any paid game sets sold in the Marketplace.                                 | Only viable with a large enough community to make selling sets worthwhile. Requires Stripe or similar payment infrastructure. |

## What to Put Behind the Pro Tier (Good Candidates)

These are features users want but that do not exist today — so adding them to a paid tier does not remove anything currently free:

- Unlimited saved projects (free tier gets 5–10)
- Private sets — visible only to you, not listed in the public library
- Export to standard notation formats (PGN, FEN-equivalent for custom games)
- Custom branding on shared room links (remove the Chessperiment watermark)
- Advanced piece logic blocks — more complex conditional triggers reserved for Pro
- Larger board size limits (e.g. free tier capped at 12x12, Pro uncapped)
- Priority move validation — Pro games get faster server processing

## What to Never Put Behind a Paywall

These are the things that define what Chessperiment is. Locking them would cause immediate community backlash and hand competitors a marketing gift:

- Creating and playing games — the core loop must stay free forever
- Multiplayer via room links — this is the viral growth mechanism
- Browsing the public library / Marketplace
- Basic piece editor access and standard logic blocks
- Hexagonal boards and custom board shapes — these are key differentiators, not premium additions

## Pricing Reference: Competitors

| Platform               | Free tier              | Paid tier           | Notes                                                                 |
|------------------------|------------------------|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Chess Remix            | Limited creation tools | ~\$5/month          | Core features locked — our biggest differentiator is being fully free |
| Omnichess              | Full access            | None (ad-supported) | Monetises via ads — messy UX, user complaint driver                   |
| Tabletop Simulator     | \$19.99 one-time       | DLC packs           | Different category — not a direct competitor for pricing reference    |
| Chessperiment (target) | Full access forever    | €3–5/month Pro      | Match or undercut Chess Remix. Never match Omnichess's ad model.      |

*The 200 DAU tip jar requires zero development work and can go live this week. Everything else waits until the user milestones are hit and you have survey data to back the decisions.*